MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION October 2025.

Third SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Elective (DSE) - MG3DSEHIS202 – INTRODUCING ARCHAEOLOGY

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

ANSWER SCHEME

Part A- MCQ-Each question carries 1 marks

1. Which branch of anthropology is closest to archaeology?
Answ: b)

2. Early historic period in India is generally dated to
Answ: b)

3. Which of the following is an example of experimental archaeology?
Answ: a)

4. Environmental archaeology studies
Answ: b)

5. Marine archaeology deals with
Answ: a)

6. Which of the following is a form of documentation?
Answ: d)

7. Visualization techniques in archaeology include
Answ: a)

8. Archaeological ethics involve
Answ: a)

9. Museums preserve
Answ: d)

10. Punch-marked coins belong to
Answ: b)

11. A trench in archaeology is
Answ: b)

12. The father of Indian prehistory is
Answ: c)

Part B -SHORT ANSWER

Each question carries **2** marks

13. Why is archaeology relevant in the present world?
Archaeology is relevant today as it connects the past with the present, revealing human evolution, cultural diversity, and technological progress. It helps societies

preserve heritage, understand identity, and learn from past environmental and social changes. Archaeology promotes sustainable development, education, and intercultural understanding in a rapidly changing world.

14. Why is geoarchaeology significant?

Geoarchaeology is significant because it integrates geological methods to understand archaeological sites within their natural contexts. It helps reconstruct ancient landscapes, identify site formation processes, and interpret human–environment interactions. Through soil, sediment, and stratigraphic analyses, geoarchaeology provides crucial insights into past climates, resource use, and settlement patterns, enhancing archaeological interpretation.

15. Why is experimental archaeology significant?

Experimental archaeology is significant as it reconstructs ancient technologies, tools, and processes through practical experimentation. By replicating past techniques such as pottery making, metalworking, or tool use, it bridges theory and practice, helping archaeologists understand craftsmanship, resource use, and human behavior, while testing hypotheses about ancient life and cultural adaptation.

16. Why is archaeobotany important in understanding agriculture?

Archaeobotany is important in understanding agriculture as it analyzes plant remains from archaeological sites to trace crop origins, cultivation practices, and dietary habits. It reveals domestication processes, environmental adaptations, and trade patterns, helping reconstruct ancient farming systems and their role in shaping early economies, settlements, and human–environment relationships.

17. Mention one tool or equipment used in underwater archaeology.

Underwater archaeology employs tools such as diving suits, scuba gear, air tanks, underwater cameras, sonar systems, GPS, dredges, metal detectors, and submersibles. Excavation tools include trowels, brushes, water dredges, and measuring tapes. Recording equipment like underwater slates, video recorders, and photogrammetry tools aid in documentation and site mapping.

18. Mention two excavation methods.

Two major excavation methods in archaeology are **vertical excavation** and **horizontal excavation**. Vertical excavation explores layers or strata to study chronological development and cultural sequence, often through trenches or pits. Horizontal excavation exposes wider areas of the same layer to understand settlement patterns, structures, and spatial organization of ancient sites.

19. Why is GIS used in exploration?

GIS (Geographic Information System) is used in archaeological exploration to collect, analyze, and visualize spatial data. It helps map sites, study landscape relationships, and identify patterns of human activity. By integrating remote sensing, topography, and environmental data, GIS enhances site prediction, management, and interpretation of archaeological distributions across regions.

20. How does literature supplement archaeological data?

Literature supplements archaeological data by providing historical context, cultural references, and descriptions of events, places, and traditions mentioned in texts. Ancient writings, inscriptions, and epics help interpret material evidence, confirm dates, and identify sites or rulers, allowing a more comprehensive reconstruction of past societies through the integration of textual and material sources.

Part C- SHORT ESSAY

Each question carries 5 marks

21. Write a short note on the contribution of coins to historic studies

Coins contribute significantly to historical studies as they provide concrete evidence of political authority, economic systems, and cultural expressions. They help identify rulers, dynasties, and chronological sequences through inscriptions and portraits. The metals, weights, and mint marks reveal trade networks and technological progress. Artistic motifs and symbols on coins reflect religious beliefs and cultural trends, while hoards indicate commercial links and territorial control. By correlating numismatic data with archaeological and literary sources, historians can reconstruct patterns of governance, economy, and intercultural contact. Thus, coins serve as vital and reliable tools for understanding diverse aspects of past civilizations.

22. Explain the features of protohistoric archaeology.

Protohistoric archaeology studies cultures that existed before written records in their own language but are mentioned in external sources. It bridges prehistory and history, focusing on the emergence of urbanism, metallurgy, trade, and social organization. Key features include the use of material evidence like pottery, tools, and architecture; development of writing or proto-writing systems; evidence of agriculture and animal domestication; and increasing regional interaction. Protohistoric archaeology relies on interdisciplinary methods combining archaeology, anthropology, and linguistics to reconstruct early civilizations' lifestyles, technology, and cultural evolution, especially during the transition from the Neolithic to the early historic period.

23. Explain how archaeozoology contributes to subsistence studies.

Archaeozoology contributes greatly to subsistence studies by analyzing animal remains from archaeological sites to reconstruct past diets, hunting patterns, and domestication processes. It identifies species used for food, tools, or rituals and reveals seasonal occupations and resource management. Through bone, shell, and faunal analysis, archaeozoology helps understand environmental adaptation, trade, and economic organization. It also distinguishes between wild and domestic species, offering evidence of technological advancements like herding or fishing. By linking faunal data with botanical and material findings, archaeozoology provides a holistic view of ancient subsistence strategies and human–environment interactions essential for understanding cultural evolution.

24. Write a note on radiocarbon dating.

Radiocarbon dating is a scientific method used to determine the age of organic materials by measuring the decay of carbon-14 isotopes. It is effective for samples up to about 50,000 years old. Materials like wood, charcoal, bone, shell, and seeds are commonly dated. The technique is based on the principle that living organisms absorb carbon-14, which begins to decay after death. By calculating the remaining carbon-14, archaeologists can estimate the time since death. Radiocarbon dating revolutionized archaeology by providing absolute dates, helping establish chronological frameworks, verify cultural sequences, and correlate archaeological, environmental, and historical events with scientific precision.

25. Discuss the significance of field archaeology in archaeological studies.

Field archaeology is significant as it forms the foundation of all archaeological research by systematically locating, excavating, and recording sites. It provides firsthand data on material culture, settlement patterns, and environmental contexts. Techniques like surveying, mapping, and stratigraphic excavation help reconstruct human activities and cultural development. Fieldwork ensures accurate documentation, preservation, and interpretation of artefacts within their original context. It also aids in understanding spatial organization, trade connections, and site chronology. Through interdisciplinary collaboration and scientific methods, field archaeology bridges theory and evidence, offering a comprehensive understanding of past societies and their interaction with the natural landscape.

26. Discuss the role of inscriptions in reconstructing political history.

Inscriptions play a crucial role in reconstructing political history as they provide direct and authentic records of rulers, dynasties, and administrative systems. They reveal details about conquests, boundary extensions, taxation, and governance. Royal edicts, grants, and proclamations inscribed on stone or metal record achievements and religious patronage. Inscriptions help establish accurate chronology and genealogy of kings, clarify regional interactions, and confirm events mentioned in literature. They serve as primary evidence for understanding political organization, power distribution, and cultural integration. Thus, epigraphic studies form the backbone of reconstructing the political and administrative history of ancient and medieval societies.

27. Discuss the role of radiocarbon dating in archaeology

Radiocarbon dating plays a vital role in archaeology as it provides a scientific method to determine the absolute age of organic materials. By measuring the decay of carbon-14 isotopes in remains such as wood, charcoal, bone, or shell, archaeologists can establish accurate timelines up to about 50,000 years. This method helps verify cultural sequences, synchronize archaeological layers, and compare developments across regions. Radiocarbon dating has revolutionized archaeological research by replacing relative dating techniques with precise chronological frameworks, enabling a deeper understanding of human evolution, technological progress, and environmental changes that shaped past civilizations and cultural transitions.

Part D- ESSAY QUESTION
Each question carries 15 marks

28. Critically examine the role of art and architecture in reconstructing Indian history.

Art and architecture serve as vital sources for reconstructing Indian history, reflecting the cultural, political, and religious evolution of the subcontinent. Their study helps trace chronological developments and regional variations in style and technique. Reveal socio-political conditions through patronage and state-sponsored monuments.--Indicate economic prosperity and technological advancement in construction and materials.----Depict religious transformations—Buddhist stupas, Hindu temples, Jain caves, and Islamic monuments show changing faiths and syncretism.--Reflect regional diversity through architectural styles—Nagara, Dravida, Vesara, Indo-Islamic, etc.---Provide insights into aesthetic values, symbolism, and craftsmanship.---Record historical events and rulers through inscriptions, reliefs, and murals---Serve as evidence of urban planning, trade links, and foreign influences (Greco-Buddhist, Persian, etc.).----Help establish chronology when literary or inscriptional data are lacking.---Contribute to understanding cultural continuity and transformation over time.---Represent integration of art, religion, and politics as tools of expression and legitimacy---In conclusion, the study of art and architecture complements literary and archaeological evidence, offering a multidimensional understanding of India's historical development, identity, and heritage through tangible and enduring cultural expressions

29. Evaluate the contribution of oral traditions to the reconstruction of cultural history?

Oral traditions play a crucial role in reconstructing cultural history, especially where written records are absent. They preserve collective memory and transmit cultural values across generations. – Provide insights into myths, legends, songs, folktales, and genealogies that reflect social beliefs and practices. – Help identify historical events, heroes, and community origins. – Offer evidence of cultural continuity, migration, and intergroup interactions. – Reflect linguistic evolution, regional identity, and performance traditions. – Complement archaeological and ethnographic data in understanding intangible heritage. – Preserve indigenous knowledge systems, rituals, and ecological wisdom. – Serve as living archives of marginalized or non-literate societies. – Aid in reconstructing histories of tribes, local kingdoms, and folk movements. – Help interpret symbolic meanings embedded in rituals and oral performances. – Require critical evaluation to distinguish historical fact from myth or exaggeration. In conclusion, oral traditions bridge the gap between material culture and lived experience, providing a human dimension to cultural history. When used with corroborative evidence, they enrich historical

reconstruction by integrating memory, belief, and social identity into the broader narrative of civilization.

30. Ethnoarchaeology acts as a bridge between the present and the past. Discuss with suitable examples? Ethnoarchaeology acts as a bridge between the present and the past by studying living communities to interpret ancient cultural practices. It helps archaeologists understand how tools, artefacts, and structures were made and used. – Establishes connections between traditional societies and archaeological evidence. – Provides analogies for interpreting material culture and site formation processes. – Aids in understanding technological continuity such as pottery making, iron smelting, and tool manufacture. – Helps reconstruct subsistence patterns, settlement organization, and ritual behavior. – Offers insights into cultural adaptation and environmental interaction. – Strengthens interpretation of megalithic, neolithic, and tribal contexts through ethnographic parallels. – Example: studies of blacksmiths in Kerala explain iron tool traditions; tribal burial practices relate to megalithic monuments. – Highlights living traditions as sources of cultural continuity. In conclusion, ethnoarchaeology integrates ethnographic observation with archaeological interpretation, bridging the temporal gap and enabling a deeper understanding of human behavior, technology, and social organization in both ancient and modern contexts.

31. Discuss the relationship between archaeology and history in reconstructing India's past? Archaeology and history are closely interrelated disciplines that together reconstruct India's past through material and written evidence. – History depends on written records such as inscriptions, manuscripts, and chronicles, while archaeology provides physical evidence like artefacts, monuments, and settlements. – Archaeology helps fill gaps where literary sources are silent or lost. – Correlation of archaeological data with historical texts validates chronology and events. – Material remains reveal economic life, technology, and social organization beyond elite narratives. – Inscriptions and coins discovered archaeologically strengthen historical interpretation. – Excavations at sites like Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro, and Hastinapur have redefined early Indian chronology. – Art, architecture, and iconography provide insights into religion, polity, and culture. – Archaeology offers a non-literary perspective on common people and everyday life. – Combined study aids in understanding political transitions, trade networks, and cultural continuity. – Integrating archaeological evidence with historical sources ensures a scientific and comprehensive reconstruction of India's civilization. In conclusion, archaeology and history complement each other—history provides narrative depth, while archaeology offers tangible proof—together creating a balanced, multi-dimensional understanding of India's cultural and historical development.